

farmer with tobacco and fish hooks—and above all, with news. How hungry people used to be for news! The peddlers invariably had more money than the farmers, for they performed the valuable function of bringing producer and consumer together.

When the farmer wanted to sell or buy a horse, he often was assisted by a broker who helped both parties reach an agreement on price, then sealed the bargain by making them shake hands. The broker, too, generally made more money than the farmers because he brought producer and consumer together.

Recently I read of complaints by shoppers in the Soviet Union. It seems they spend endless hours standing on line in front of separate, specialized food stores. Eventually they may adopt the American idea of bringing many producers and many consumers together in convenient supermarkets.

Fortunes have been made in this revolution in merchandising, especially as supermarkets—and their sprawling parking lots—have moved into the suburbs and even far out into the country. Fringe benefits have come to many property owners who saw how to ride along with the trend.

A woman lived alone on twenty poor acres which had mostly been taken over by scrub pine. At last she decided to sell the old homestead. Neighbors told her, sighing, that she would never get much for it. A local real estate man made her a pitiable offer.

This woman, however, was one of those elderly (in years) people who never had seen any reason why her mind should not remain alert. She told herself that her farm must be good for *something*. She decided to spend thirty days in an intensive investigation of what run-down farms are good for. Before the end of that thirty days she had found she could sell it as a base for a riding stable, complete with pasture and pleasant riding trails, for twice what the real estate man had offered.

But also she had studied several supermarkets in the area and had concluded that her farm would make a good supermarket site. She sold out finally to a supermarket for five times what the real estate man had offered.

When roads were paved and transportation by automobile became so easy, it was predicted that the mail-order house would disappear. After all, why should a person buy from a catalog when he can buy from the store itself? Such firms as